The Mihai Eminescu Trust

NEWSLETTER 2014

ROYAL HONOUR AWARDED TO JESSICA DOUGLAS-HOME

Jessica Douglas-Home, chairman of the Mihai Eminescu Trust, was presented with the honour of Knight in the Order of the Crown by HRH Crown Princess Margareta of Romania, on behalf of His Majesty King Michael I. The Order of the Crown recognises individuals whose outstanding achievements have contributed significantly to the well-being of the country and its residents.

"For her tireless work with the Mihai Eminescu Trust, supporting culture and freedom in Romania. For her courage, noted in the most difficult times of the recent past, and the love she has shown for Romania. For promoting Romanian values at home and abroad, being a true cultural ambassador of our country".

In 1986, during the Ceaușescu era, she founded the Mihai Eminescu Trust to help philosophers, historians, artists and writers under oppression, by bringing to them the intellectual material they needed to keep abreast with their peers in the rest of the world. She especially acknowledges Professor Constantin Noica, Andrei Pleșu and Gabriel Liiceanu, who guided her in this sometimes difficult endeavour.



The Trust went on to resist Ceaușescu's systematisation plan to demolish thousands of Romanian villages. After the dictator's downfall, the Trust took on the mission of restoring and safeguarding Romania's ancient heritage, especially in Transylvania.

The Trust can look back at 14 years of work in Romanian villages, led by Caroline Fernolend, the MET's Executive Director. During those years, the Trust has completed the restoration of more than 1,200 buildings, including bridges, libraries, barns, schools, museums, streetscapes, synagogues and churches of every denomination and has planted over a million trees. With its "Whole Village Project" the Trust emphasises economic regeneration as much as the preservation of Romania's beautiful built and natural heritage.

BREAKING NEWS

Work has started this March on restoring the four Towers and inner buildings of the magnificent Saxon church fortification in Alma Vii. In competition with 200 applicants, the Mihai Eminescu Trust, partnered by EEA Grants and the Norwegian Institute for Cultural Heritage Research, was awarded the EUR 1.7 million contract. An update on this amazing project will appear at intervals during the next two years.



EXPERIENCE TRANSYLVANIA – CULTURAL AND ECOLOGICAL TOURISM

With help and encouragement from the Horizon Foundation, as part of a larger communication project for the MET, a new brand has been established called Experience Transylvania. MET guesthouses from Alma Vii to Viscri can now be booked online under the name *www.experiencetransylvania.ro*. The aim is to further develop and improve the standards of traditional tourist services available in Transylvanian villages, to allow guests to easily find information about the Transylvanian culture and tourist attractions, to choose and book a guesthouse and to pay online.

Cultural and ecological tourism is one of the key components of the Whole Village Project. The MET has been con-

stantly involved in the development of this branch of the rural economic environment by restoring abandoned traditional houses and turning them into guesthouses, under the management of local families. This has achieved success in setting new standards for traditional accommodation and improving the lives of a great number of villagers thanks to the home-grown products and the charming services they have created for tourists.

TRANSYLVANIAN FLOWERS – EDUCATIONAL PROJECT FOR CHILDREN

"Transylvanian Flowers" – Project for the promotion of traditional wood restoration and painting has been funded by the National Cultural Fund Administration and carried out by the MET in partnership with schools in Laslea and Bunești communes. The cultural and historical value of the heritage found in the villages demonstrates the importance of the preservation and restoration of painted wooden objects.

During the 6 months of the project 30 students from schools in 7 villages and two communes identified and catalogued traditionally painted wooden pieces of furniture.

Two of these objects were professionally restored with the process turned into a video and published online. Images have been exhibited in schools and published in a brochure alongside information about restoration techniques.

The pupils developed a basic understanding of Transylvanian painted furniture and its role in the culture of the local population. They participated in seminars, visited the Astra Village Museum in Sibiu, and photographed the traditional painted flower furniture they had discovered.

A FOREST FOR EVERY SCHOOL GAINS TWO AWARDS AT CIVIL SOCIETY GALA

Mihai Eminescu Trust received two first prizes in the sections *'Environmental Protection'* and *'Impact'* at the *Civil Society Gala* for the project called *A Forest For Every School*, developed in partnership with the French *Accor Hotels Group*. The millionth tree was planted by His Royal Highness The Prince of Wales along with MET Vice-president, Caroline Fernolend. The Trust aims to plant three million in seven countries.

The Project aims to improve the natural landscape by preserving and expanding forests, reforesting degraded areas and raising popular awareness of the importance of the environment. Educational activities involve teachers, pupils and whole communities in the planting process and is overseen by the Trust with help from 60 schools, 52 municipalities and associations and 11 forest districts.

The award ceremony of the XII Civil Society Gala was held on the 10th of June at the Romanian Athenaeum and was attended and supported by more than 700 representatives of the private and public sector in Romania, academics, journalists, researchers, and opinion leaders from civil society.

SCHOOL ORCHARDS RETURN TO TRANSYLVANIA

School orchards used to be present in villages throughout Transylvania, but unfortunately, most were abandoned or destroyed during the communist years. Their pear and plum trees in particular helped teachers show students the mysteries of horticulture: how and when trees should be planted, how to care for them and how to graft and to harvest their produce. In reviving this practice, the MET hopes to preserve and re-establish local fruit varieties, reintroduce horticulture into school curricula, and also encourage students to eat more fruit.

The Brăduţ and Homorod Town Halls kindly provided the land plots for planting two orchards. In November the MET contributed tools and seedlings and built fences to enclose the two orchards, in collaboration with „Benkő József" Secondary School in Brăduţ, under the aegis of the Accor "Plant for the Planet" project. Students were trained by a local coordinator on how to plant a tree correctly, and planted 32 varieties of seedlings, the first new school orchard. A second orchard, with 30 traditional varieties was planted in Homorod, in cooperation with the local Secondary School. This orchard was co-financed through Switzerland's contribution to the EU, and implemented in partnership with the Swiss SAVE Foundation. The schools will be responsible for their care and growth monitoring for the next 20 years.

NORWEGIAN GRANTS PROJECT

In partnership with the Centre for Social Development, the Mihai Eminescu Trust launched a new project funded by EEA Grants: *"Multiculturalism – Engine for Sustainable Community Development"*. The project started in July 2014 and will last for 18 months. The aim is to reduce social differences and increase cohesion in six Transylvanian multi-ethnic villages (Moşna, Biertan, Copşa Mare, Richiş, Nemşa and Alma Vii), as well as to help organise local events and conferences.

The MET will follow through development plans in two of the villages and help organise programmes for children and adults. We will also encourage and support local business plans.

EMERGENCY INTERVENTION AT THE BUTCHERS' TOWER IN SIGHIȘOARA

The Mihai Eminescu Trust in partnership with Liviu Tudor Foundation and Horizon Foundation has begun a project for the restoration of the Butchers' Tower, which once belonged to the ancient guild of butchers, and stands on the ramparts of the 15th century Sighisoara Citadel. The project began in the spring with extensive emergency work. The technical and architectural studies will be completed by the end of 2015.

Festum Development SA and the Horizon Foundation have together funded the project's first two stages. We are looking for new partners for the final stage of the restoration, which will provide access to the tower for Sighisoara inhabitants and tourists, and show a model conversion of a historical monument.

The Trust will provide project management and logistical support. The work will be carried out by craftsmen trained in traditional construction techniques, under the MET principles for historic buildings. The team will include experienced specialists in the restoration of historical monuments, it will be coordinated by an architect accredited by the Ministry of Culture, and local labour will be employed to support the village and town economies and to involve local people in the protection of their heritage.

RESTORATION BEGINS AT 103 RICHIS

Following the success of the Apafi Manor in Mălâncrav, the Trust is undertaking a new restoration of No 103 in the village of Richis. Although smaller in scale than the Apafi project, the aims are similar. The house will provide accommodation for 9. Once again David Mlinaric is generously giving his time and advice on the interior. In order to complete the magnificent music room and library, and 3 especially beautiful bedrooms, all with ceramic stoves, we need to raise a final £50,500.



OTHER NEWS

JANUARY

SIR NOEL MALCOLM

MET Trustee, Dr Noel Malcolm, was appointed a Knight Bachelor in the 2014 New Year's Honours List in recognition of his work on the political philosopher Thomas Hobbes; his scholarship in the field of the cultures, languages, and politics of Eastern Europe; his lectures on Western relations with Islam; and his political journalism.



Sir Noel Malcolm

MARCH

POETRY READING FOR 'FRIENDS' BY DOMINIC WEST

The year's presentation for 'Friends' of the Mihai Eminescu Trust was held at the Embassy of Romania in London. MET Chairman Jessica Douglas-Home thanked the Romanian Ambassador (His Excellency Dr Ion Jinga) for his support over the years. Marianne Suhr, specialist in the repair of historic buildings and co-presenter of BBC2's Restoration, quoting Samuel Johnson "Nothing will ever be attempted if all possible objections must first be overcome", noted the MET's remarkable ability to overcome the bureaucratic difficulties of working in Transylvania. She said: 'If only more people had the courage and tenacity to just go for it, the world would be a more beautiful and interesting place'. Dominic West then read poems by Mihai Eminescu, including *Ode*, *Eve on the Hill*, *And if..*, and *Down Where the Lonely Poplars Grow*.



Dominic West

AUGUST

RESTORATION OF WHITE STONE SPRING AT PLĂIEȘII DE JOS

In Eastern Transylvania, in the Székely Land, the Mihai Eminescu Trust, and the Plăieșii de Jos villagers, celebrated the restoration of the pavilion and its surroundings at the White Stone mineral water spring. Village craftsmen also made signs for routes on foot to the spring.

The Trust, Plăieșii de Jos Town Hall and the local Forestry Association organised the project together with the support of 190 volunteers from the village and with the financial support from the Horizon Foundation.

SEPTEMBER

MET SUPPORT FOR DRIVE TO PROTECT ANCIENT WOOD-PASTURES

A new documentary film by Tibor Hartel (biologist and adviser to the Mihai Eminescu Trust) explores the agricultural and environmental significance of the ancient wood pastures of Transylvania.

OCTOBER

APPLE DAY IN MALANCRAV

An 'Apple Day' was held by villagers to celebrate the end of the picking season in the orchards of Mălâncrav. There were tours along the 'Apple Path', demonstrations of work, and displays of a wide range of fruit, including the old native varieties. A buffet lunch prepared by the ladies of the village was served with delicious home-made bread, while local musicians entertained the visitors.

The event formed part of a two year project begun by the MET and the SAVE foundation from Switzerland in 2013, the aim is to add value to native fruit varieties and to traditional farming methods as a way of achieving sustainable income for rural communities. The project is co-financed through Switzerland's contribution to the enlarged EU. The project titled *"Sustainable agriculture in deprived areas in Romania: Conservation and exploitation of fruit varieties"*.

DECEMBER

ONCE UPON A TIME IN SIGHIȘOARA

The Mihai Eminescu Trust, supported by the German Consulate in Sibiu, initiated a project for students to research on historic photographs. Most families own old prints and postcards in their archives and with the cooperation of the "Joseph Haltrich" secondary school in Sighișoara and helped by their history teachers, the MET encouraged pupils to uncover such lost treasures relating to Sighisoara culture and history.

Forty photos, postcards and old documents were discovered and were accompanied by short stories revealing the illustrated moment and its relevance to the respective families or communities. The images were scanned and edited and made into large prints and exhibited for two months inside the Tourism Information Centre in Sighișoara. Mrs. Judith Urban, General Consul of the Federal Republic of Germany in Sibiu and Caroline Fernolend, opened the exhibition in December, in the presence of Sighișoara City Hall officials, members of the German Democratic Forum, invited guests, journalists, teachers and pupils from the "Joseph Haltrich" school.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The projects described above are only a selection of the highlight from projects completed during 2014.

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Partners: Horizon Foundation, Accor France, Fundatia Liviu Tudor, EEA Grants- through the NGO Fund in Romania, Grant from Switzerland through the Swiss Contribution to the enlarged European Union, AFCN - National Cultural Fund Administration, POS Mediu, Town Hall Bistrita, Consulat of the Federal Republic of Germany in Sibiu, Council of Europe.

We thank all those who joined Friends of the MET, and for the generous donations from Alice and Simon Boyd, Marcia Brocklebank, Max Egremont, JoJo and Jonathan Hull, Rodney Leach, Shropshire Firefighters, Colin Richards & his team, Markus Schmitz, Ernst Leonhard, Bocskai Zoltan and the Kestrelman Trust.

OTHER INFORMATION

The achievements of the Trust are only made possible by your donations. Please send any offering to either of our offices. Over its first 12 years the MET benefited from the remarkable generosity of the Packard Humanities Institute. Their programme of giving came to a conclusion two years ago so, in order to continue with our restoration projects we must look elsewhere for our fund raising, which makes every grant or donation all the more valuable.

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